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The Dark Mysteries of The Lalaurie Mansion

New Orleans' House of Horrors and Madame Lalaurie's Secret Attic

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Introduction

The Lalaurie Mansion stands at 1140 Royal Street in the French Quarter of New Orleans, Louisiana. It is a three-story building, constructed circa 1832 in the Federal style, with a facade that gives no hint of the horrors that were discovered within its walls. The mansion is one of the most notorious buildings in a city that is itself famous for its dark history -- a city of voodoo, slavery, yellow fever epidemics, and centuries of violence. New Orleans has no shortage of haunted houses, but the Lalaurie Mansion is widely considered the most haunted of them all, and the most evil.

The mansion's infamy is rooted in the events of April 1834, when a fire broke out in the kitchen of the house. When neighbors and firefighters entered the building to rescue the inhabitants, they discovered in the attic a scene of such horror that it would shock the city of New Orleans and the nation. Enslaved people were found chained to walls, subjected to mutilation, starvation, and torture that defied description. The discovery provoked a mob of thousands to descend on the house, destroying what they could. The owner of the mansion -- Madame Delphine Lalaurie, a prominent figure in New Orleans Creole society -- fled the city and was never seen there again.

Delphine Lalaurie was born Marie Delphine Macarty in 1787, into a prominent Creole family in New Orleans. She married three times -- first to a Spanish officer, then to the banker and lawyer Jean Blanque, and finally to Leonard Louis Nicolas Lalaurie, a physician. By all accounts, she was a beautiful and charming woman who moved in the highest circles of New Orleans society. She was known for her elegance, her parties, and her social standing. Behind the facade of respectability, however, lay a capacity for cruelty that the discovery in the attic would reveal to the world.

The Lalaurie Mansion has been associated with paranormal activity since the events of 1834. Reports of screams, moaning, and phantom footsteps have been documented for nearly two hundred years. The building has served multiple purposes over the decades -- as a private residence, as apartments, as a school for African-American girls during Reconstruction, and as the temporary home of the actor Nicolas Cage. Each incarnation has brought its own reports of the supernatural, and each has added a layer to the mansion's dark reputation.

The Lalaurie Mansion brings New Orleans to the Dark Mysteries series, which examines haunted and historically significant locations around the world. The Lalaurie Mansion is a unique entry in the series because the haunting is rooted not in a vague or distant past but in a specific, documented, and horrific event -- the torture of enslaved people by their owner, a crime that was witnessed and reported by the people of New Orleans in 1834. The ghosts of the Lalaurie Mansion, if they exist, are the ghosts of real victims of real crimes, and the question of whether they still walk the halls of 1140 Royal Street is inseparable from the question of justice -- whether the victims of one of the most notorious acts of cruelty in American history have been allowed to rest, or whether their suffering continues, in some form, within the walls of the house where it occurred.

The story of the Lalaurie Mansion has been told and retold for nearly two hundred years, and it has been amplified by each retelling -- by newspaper accounts, by ghost tours, by television shows, and by the enduring fascination of the public with stories of cruelty and the supernatural. The question of what actually happened at 1140 Royal Street in 1834, and what continues to happen there, is complicated by the layers of legend that have accumulated around the historical facts. The task of this book, as with every volume in the Dark Mysteries series, is to penetrate those layers -- to identify what is known, what is believed, and what is unknowable -- and to present the story of the Lalaurie Mansion with the seriousness and the respect that its subjects deserve.

The Lalaurie Mansion is not the only haunted location in New Orleans -- the city is filled with buildings that are said to be haunted, from the Bourbon Orleans Hotel to the Hotel Provincial to the La Pavilion Hotel. But the Lalaurie Mansion occupies a special place in the city's ghost lore because the events that caused the haunting are so extreme and so well documented. Other haunted houses in New Orleans are associated with vague legends of tragic deaths and unquiet spirits. The Lalaurie Mansion is associated with a specific, witnessed, and historically documented act of cruelty that shocked the city in 1834 and that continues to shock those who hear the story nearly two centuries later. The specificity and the extremity of the event give the Lalaurie haunting a power that more generalized ghost stories cannot match.

Chapter 1: What Happened Here?

The Lalaurie Mansion is located at 1140 Royal Street, on the corner of Royal and Governor Nicholls Streets, in the heart of the French Quarter of New Orleans. The French Quarter, or Vieux Carré, is the oldest neighborhood in the

city, founded by the French in 1718 and later transferred to Spanish control before becoming part of the United States through the Louisiana Purchase of 1803. The architecture of the French Quarter is a mixture of French, Spanish, and American influences, with wrought-iron balconies, courtyards, and narrow streets that have changed little in two centuries. The Lalaurie Mansion is a three-story Federal-style building, with a facade that is typical of the period -- elegant, restrained, and giving no indication of the horrors that were discovered within.

The mansion was built circa 1832 for Delphine Lalaurie and her third husband, Leonard Louis Nicolas Lalaurie, a physician. The house was one of the finest in the French Quarter, reflecting the wealth and social standing of its owner. Delphine Lalaurie was known for her parties, her elegance, and her position at the top of Creole society. The house, with its multiple rooms, its courtyard, and its attic, was the setting for the life of a wealthy New Orleans family -- and for the hidden atrocities that were concealed behind the elegant facade.

The location of the mansion -- on a busy street in the most famous neighborhood of one of America's most storied cities -- has contributed to its enduring fame. The house is visible, accessible, and known. Ghost tours pass it nightly. Tourists photograph it. The building has been a landmark of horror for nearly two centuries, and its presence on Royal Street -- a street that is, in daylight, one of the most beautiful in New Orleans -- creates a contrast between the beauty of the setting and the darkness of the history that is central to the Lalaurie story.

On the morning of April 10, 1834, a fire broke out in the kitchen of the Lalaurie Mansion. The fire was started, according to contemporary accounts, by a enslaved cook who was chained to the stove and who set the kitchen ablaze in an act of desperation -- choosing death by fire over continued captivity. When neighbors and firefighters entered the house to fight the fire and rescue the inhabitants, they discovered the cook, still chained, and they discovered what lay beyond the kitchen door.

In the attic of the mansion, the rescuers found a room that contained enslaved people in conditions of unspeakable horror. According to the accounts that circulated in the aftermath, the enslaved people were chained to walls and to beds, their bodies mutilated and disfigured. Some had been subjected to crude surgical procedures -- limbs broken and reset at unnatural angles, skin removed, organs exposed. The descriptions, preserved in newspaper accounts of the period, are so extreme that some historians have questioned their accuracy, but the fact that something horrific was discovered in the attic is not in dispute. The discovery was witnessed by multiple people, and it provoked an immediate and violent response.

The news of what had been found in the attic spread through New Orleans within hours. An angry mob, estimated in the thousands, descended on the Lalaurie Mansion, destroying furniture, smashing windows, and tearing the interior apart. The mob's rage was directed at the house and at its owner -- at the visible symbol of the cruelty that had been concealed within. Delphine Lalaurie, according to the accounts, fled the house during the chaos, escaping in a carriage with her driver. She was never seen in New Orleans again.

Delphine Lalaurie's flight from New Orleans is one of the most dramatic escapes in the history of American crime. She left behind her mansion, her possessions, her social standing, and the city where she had been a leading figure. According to the most widely accepted accounts, she fled to Paris, where she lived under the name of her second husband, Blanque, until her death on December 7, 1849. Her body was reportedly returned to New Orleans and buried in St. Louis Cemetery No. 1, though the location of her grave is disputed.

The mansion itself survived the mob's destruction and passed through a series of owners and uses over the following decades. It served as a private residence, as apartments, as a school, and as a temporary home for various tenants. Each incarnation brought new reports of paranormal activity -- screams, footsteps, apparitions, and a pervasive sense of evil that was attributed to the spirits of the enslaved people who had been tortured and killed in the attic. The mansion's reputation as the most haunted house in New Orleans was established within years of the 1834 fire and has been maintained, without interruption, for nearly two centuries.

The mansion's design -- with its multiple floors, its courtyard, and its attic -- was typical of wealthy New Orleans residences of the period. The courtyard, a feature of French Quarter architecture, provided ventilation and light in a climate where both were essential. The attic, accessible by a narrow staircase, was used for storage and, in the Lalaurie household, for something far more sinister. The layout of the house -- with its public rooms on the lower floors and its private spaces above -- created a clear division between the life that Delphine Lalaurie showed to the world and the life she concealed. The attic, at the top of the house, was the most private space of all -- a space that visitors never entered and that servants may not have known about.

The discovery of the attic's contents in 1834 revealed the distance between Delphine's public image and her private reality -- between the elegant hostess and the torturer.

The French Quarter setting also contributes to the mansion's atmosphere. The Vieux Carré is a neighborhood of narrow streets, wrought-iron balconies, hidden courtyards, and centuries-old buildings, and its physical character -- dark, enclosed, and historically dense -- creates an atmosphere that is naturally conducive to ghost stories. The neighborhood is quiet at night, when the tourist traffic shifts to Bourbon Street, and the silence of Royal Street after dark gives the Lalaurie Mansion a presence that is more intense than it would be in a busier location. The mansion, standing on a corner, visible from multiple angles, with its three-story facade and its dark windows, is an imposing structure that dominates the intersection, and at night, when the street is empty, it is easy to see why witnesses report feeling a sense of unease in its presence.

The fire that revealed the attic's horrors was, in a sense, an act of resistance. If the accounts are accurate, the enslaved cook who set the fire chose death by fire over continued captivity -- a choice that, in its desperation and its courage, exposed the crimes that were being concealed in the house above. The cook's act -- if it was an act of deliberate resistance -- was the catalyst for the destruction of Delphine Lalaurie's world. Without the fire, the attic might never have been discovered, and the torture might have continued. The fire, in this interpretation, was a form of justice -- imperfect, incomplete, but real. The cook, whose name is not recorded, may have been the first person to resist Delphine Lalaurie's cruelty, and the fire may have been the weapon that brought the crimes to light.

The record the cook left behind is also an irony worth naming, because the archive of the Lalaurie case preserves everything except the person who forced it open. Delphine Lalaurie's name is documented to the point of celebrity -- her births, marriages, addresses, and death date survive -- while the woman who set the fire is a single line in a newspaper account, identified by role and not by name. The same asymmetry runs through the haunting narrative that grew from the discovery. The mansion's most famous reported ghost is the perpetrator; witnesses describe a woman in the windows and a female figure moving through the house, and the tours name her readily. The victims -- the people whose suffering is the entire basis of the house's notoriety -- appear in the reports as sounds and shadows, anonymous in death as they were anonymous in the record. If the haunting is a form of memory, it is a memory that has inherited the shape of the archive it came from: the torturer remembered by name, the rescuer unrecorded, and the victims present only as an unaccountable sorrow with no name attached.